vegetable and fruits should be included. As such, carbohydrate should account for 60-65 percent of the energy.

- **Fats:** Fats should not provide more than 20 percent of the energy in the diet. Increased dietary intake of cholesterol and saturated fat has been linked with hypertension. Intake of polyunsaturated fatty acids has been shown to positively affect hypertension.
- **Sodium:** A decrease in sodium intake is associated with a decrease in blood pressure. Dietary sodium restriction is strongly recommended for the prevention and treatment of hypertension.
- **Potassium and Calcium:** Potassium along with sodium regulates the body's water balance. An adequate amount of potassium is an essential part of hypertension treatment. It can be achieved by including sufficient amount of food rich in potassium such as milk, fruits and vegetables. Studies have suggested that an optimum intake of calcium has a beneficial effect in hypertension; hence, calcium rich food like low fat milk and leafy vegetables should be included in the diet.

2. Weight management:

Obesity is clearly associated with the risk of hypertension. A 10 percent weight loss can reduce blood pressure by 7/5 mm Hg. Moreover, weight loss improves the blood lipid profile further reducing CVD risk.

3. Smoking and alcohol consumption:

Smoking cessation is the most important lifestyle modification that is required for reducing CVD risk. Excessive consumption of alcohol (binge drinking) can lead to a significant rise in blood pressure.

4. Exercise:

Regular aerobic exercise has been shown to decrease blood pressure. Active exercises such as walking, cycling and swimming for 45-60 minutes, three to four times a week has a positive impact on blood pressure.

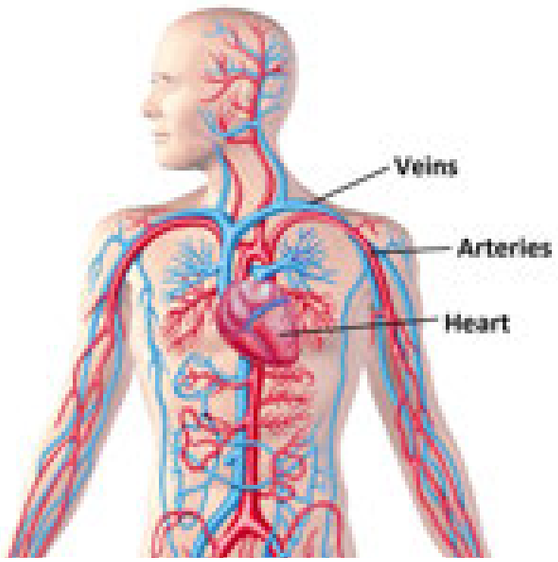


Natural Salt substitutes

Herbs and spices can be used as flavour enhancers in place of salt. Thus these natural salt substitutes may help in reducing salt intake. Some examples are basil, coriander, paprika, mint, rosemary, parsley, chives, cinnamon, oregano, nutmeg and turmeric.

11.7 CARDIOVASCULAR DISEASE

The heart is a hollow, muscular, four chambered organ, located in the centre of the chest that pumps blood to every part of the body. Blood vessels such as arteries and veins are tubular structures that carry blood to and from the heart. Therefore, the heart pumps blood through a network of arteries and veins which together comprise the cardiovascular system.



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